

THE SECRETS OF HOLIDAY WEIGHT GAIN

Good News: People don't gain as much weight during the holidays as they think

In the media, you'll often hear that the average American gains five pounds or more between Thanksgiving and New Year's Day. Is this true? Research in this area suggests no.

- Around the world, some weight gain is commonly observed during holidays (Helander, 2016).
- Daily body weight data (via smart scales) during the holidays found people only gain about 1-2 pounds.
- Some weight is temporary water weight gain (starch + sodium = water retention).

Bad News: The weight that people do gain tends to stick around

When researchers continued to monitor people's weight for the rest of the year, they noticed something troubling.

- That small amount of weight gain remained even into next autumn!
- In fact, more than half of the net weight gain that people experienced over a whole year was accumulated during the holidays (Yanovski, 2000).
- This suggests that the gradual weight gain that lots of folks see over the course of years results from multiple holiday cycles.
- Think of it as a compound effect over time: 1.5 pounds x 20 years = 30 pounds of weight gain!

Why we gain weight during the holidays

- Quantity of food, as well as frequency of events centered around eating
- Exposure to hyper-palatable, calorie-rich foods that are hard to resist
- Social influences at gatherings encouraging us to eat more
- More time indoors, in dangerous proximity to the kitchen.
- Psychosocial stress.
- Seasonal mood changes
- Diminished physical activity

Tips to maintain a healthy weight during the holidays



MAINTAIN A FLEXIBLE APPROACH TO YOUR DIET

- You're probably going to want to have some special holiday foods at some point, and that's okay.
- Black-and-white thinking around food is linked to a lack of control (Byrne, 2002)
- This can make small divergences escalate into bigger problems i.e. eating one cookie means you're off your diet, leading to multiple binges.
- Feel free to enjoy some holiday treats occasionally
- While eating a wholesome diet most of the time



ENGAGE IN SOME SELF-MONITORING

- Consistent self-monitoring can help ensure that things don't get out of hand.
- People who regularly weigh themselves are able to ward off weight gain (Mason, 2018). (just once a week may be adequate)
- Pay attention to your stress levels — stress affects our food choices!



STAY PHYSICALLY ACTIVE

- One of the strongest predictors of whether people gain holiday weight is how active they are.
- Exercise doesn't just burn calories, it also improves appetite regulation (Caruso, 2023).
- Holiday exercisers (e.g., Regular high-intensity interval training (HIIT) may not gain any weight where sedentary counterparts do (Ramirez-Jimenez, 2020).